handicapped.

On taking over, I saw for myself why the BPRD had been deliberately kept starved of resources and denied its rightful place. No serious effort had ever been made to make it an effective and productive organization lest it challenge the status quo. The organization was denigratingly talked of as an appendage that does nothing much. The scanty staff was capable, yet marginalized.

Hardly any national study worth its value had ever been conducted nor acted upon with a sense of urgency. Research was not a priority. Which is why even those few studies conducted (by research students and few others) over the years had never been placed in the public domain nor acted upon despite the tremendous advances in the field of information technology. Such studies remained stuffed into files that gathered dust. Many ordinary ones were termed 'confidential', unnecessarily. There was also an almost humiliating delegation of financial powers to the head of the organization as it had very little funds. The functional units were almost broke and the Prisons Unit (which was a policy support unit to the MHA) within the bureau was being manned by officials supposed to be discharging other important functions.

The charter of the organization was truly ambitious (see www.bprd.gov.in) and would seem impressive to an outsider. For me, it entailed a huge responsibility that had to be fulfilled in the absence of even a semblance of commensurate resources. The name Bureau of Police Research and Development was a misnomer. The position of the director general was more symbolic than substantial. Within days of joining, I sensed that the BPRD was being merely used as a back-end office by the Ministry of Home Affairs. All the suggestions made by the BPRD merely lay inert on the desks of officials.

I initiated sending every month a one-page note to the Union home minister and home secretary, which highlighted the work done at the BPRD and also important issues that were pending with the government and needed to be addressed. The first such note I sent is given below:

**Interoffice memorandum**

to: Union Home Secretary
from: Kiran Bedi, DG, BPR&D
subject: Monthly highlights from BPR&D – August 2006
cc: Honourable Union Home Minister

The following points represent key highlights of August:

1. Commenced daily 10 a.m. department-wide meetings with individual unit heads to coordinate all activities, leverage common infrastructure, cross-fertilize ideas, share working knowledge and prioritize current and future tasks.
2. Initiated full department meetings on a monthly basis to take stock of personnel and welfare issues, the first of which was held soon after taking charge.
3. Significant progress and contribution were made by the department in conjunction with expert advisors to the Police Act Draft Bill. Several suggestions and comments made by the BPR&D team were appreciated and incorporated into the draft. Two experts (one of whom was from overseas) were brought in on BPR&D recommendation. Their contributions significantly enhanced the discussion and content of the committee.